

Common terms we use in the process of importing cats and dogs into Australia.

We also provide detailed advice on the import process. This glossary of terms supports that advice. Make sure you check all steps you must follow to import your cat or dog into Australia.

Find the [step-by-step guide for your country of export](#).

Approved country

An approved country is any country, administrative region or territory, approved by us for imports of cats, dogs, and canine semen.

Australia assesses any country that wishes to export dogs and cats to Australia. We assess the animal health situation and government controls to determine if trade can proceed safely.

Approved countries have adequate animal health services and a satisfactory animal health status. This provides a high level of assurance in the treatment, management and health status of cats and dogs being imported to Australia.

We categorise approved countries by pest and disease risk. These are Group 1, Group 2 and Group 3.

Group 1 countries

- New Zealand, Norfolk Island, Cocos (Keeling) Islands

Find the [step-by-step guide for your country of export](#).

Group 2 countries

American Samoa, Bahrain, Barbados, Christmas Island, Cook Islands, Falkland Islands (Malvinas), Fiji, French Polynesia, Guam, Hawaii, Iceland, Japan, Kiribati, Mauritius, Micronesia (Federated States of), Nauru, New Caledonia, Niue, Palau, Papua New Guinea, Samoa, Singapore, Solomon Islands, Tonga (Kingdom of), Tuvalu, Vanuatu, Wallis & Futuna.

Find the [step-by-step guide for your country of export](#).

Group 3 countries

Antigua & Barbuda, Argentina, Austria, Bahamas, Belgium, Bermuda, Brunei Darussalam, Bulgaria, Canada, Cayman Islands, Chile, Croatia (Republic of), Cyprus (Republic of), Czechia (Czech Republic), Denmark (including Greenland), Estonia, Finland, France, Germany, Gibraltar, Greece, Guernsey, Hong Kong, Hungary, Ireland (Republic of), Isle of Man, Israel, Italy, Jamaica, Jersey, Kuwait, Latvia, Liechtenstein, Lithuania, Luxembourg, Macao, Malta, Monaco, Montenegro, Netherlands, Northern Mariana Islands, Norway, Poland, Portugal, Puerto Rico, Qatar, Reunion, Saint Kitts & Nevis, Saint Lucia, Saint Vincent & the Grenadines, Serbia, Seychelles, Slovakia, Slovenia, South Africa (Republic of), South Korea (Republic of), Spain (including Canary and Balearic Islands), Sweden, Switzerland,

Taiwan, Trinidad & Tobago, United Arab Emirates, United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland, United States of America (excluding Guam and Hawaii), Uruguay, Virgin Islands (British), Virgin Islands (United States of America).

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Breed

A breed is a type of cat or dog that:

- has distinctive features
- was typically developed by deliberate selection.

Competent authority

A competent authority is a government agency responsible for animal health. A competent authority may be referred to as the official overseas authority.

This may be a government veterinary service or similar. In Australia, it is us (Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry).

A competent authority in the country of export must be recognised by us. The competent authority must oversee all veterinary checks and issue a veterinary health certificate. You will need to confirm this when you contact them. Find the [competent authority in your country of export](#).

Country of export

The approved country in which the final veterinary check is performed, and the veterinary health certificate is issued. This may be different to the approved country/countries in which earlier veterinary preparations or the identity check were completed. This is the country where your animal will fly from directly to Australia.

Date of export

The export date is the date your cat or dog boards the aircraft in the country of export that will take them to Australia. If your pet travels for several days to reach the airport, the export date is the day they board the aircraft, not the day they leave home to begin their journey to the airport.

How to calculate timeframes:

When calculating timeframes, the date of the treatment or preparation counts as ‘day 0’. Timeframes such as “within 5 days of export” are counted in calendar days. For example, if your pet boards the aircraft on 10 January, the earliest date the pre-export examination can be completed is 5 January, which is within 5 calendar days before export.

Desexing

To be considered desexed:

- female dogs must have undergone ovariohysterectomy or bilateral ovariectomy
- male dogs must have undergone bilateral orchiectomy

Any other form of desexing is not accepted by the department. Dogs that have not been desexed using one of these methods must undergo testing for *Brucella canis*.

Federal government employee

A federal government employee is employed by the competent authority in the country of export. For cats being imported to Australia from the Cocos (Keeling) Islands, these employees are authorised to sign (endorse) certificates on behalf of their government. They have access to the official government stamp.

Government approved laboratory

A testing laboratory that is approved by the competent authority of that country. The veterinarian preparing your cat or dog for export will be able to determine the appropriate laboratory. We do not keep a list of approved laboratories in each country, due to frequent changes to these services.

All tests must be done in a government approved laboratory. This can be in any approved country.

Government approved veterinarian

A veterinarian that is approved:

- by the competent authority of that country
- to prepare a cat or dog for export.

You must use a government approved veterinarian (GAV) for all pre-export preparations for animals travelling from group 2 and group 3 countries. They will:

- perform all checks and treatments for your cat or dog
- prepare paperwork for the official government veterinarian, to confirm all our import conditions are met.

GAV's work in clinical settings. They are often referred to as preparing veterinarians. To find a GAV, check with the competent authority in your country. If you are bringing your cat or dog to Australia from a group 1 country, refer to the competent authority to determine the type of veterinarian or official you need.

Hybrid

A hybrid cat or dog is the result of interbreeding between 2 species or subspecies of animals.

This includes interbreeding between:

- a domestic or listed specimen and wild species or wild sub-species, or
- 2 wild species, regardless of the generational distance from the wild specimens.

Find out more on [importing live hybrid animals](#) directly from the Department of Climate Change, Energy, the Environment and Water.

Listed veterinary practice

The New Zealand Ministry for Primary Industries (NZ MPI) authorises veterinary practices that can prepare cats and dogs for export to Australia.

Veterinarians at these listed practices can sign the export certificate. They will advise if your pet's circumstance requires an official veterinarian.

The NZ MPI can provide you with a [list of authorised veterinary practices](#).

Microchip

Cats and dogs must have an ISO compatible microchip implanted for identification before commencing any pre-export preparations.

The microchip must be readable by an Avid, Trovan, Destron or other ISO compatible reader. Typically, microchips with 10 or 15 digits are ISO compliant.

Microchip numbers starting with 999 are not accepted because they are not unique. AVID microchips that are 9 digits long are not acceptable because they are not ISO compatible.

Nematodes and cestodes

Cestodes and nematodes are parasites. In a simpler term, they are types of 'worms' that live inside another creature including cats and dogs. They can cause and carry diseases.

Non-approved country

A country that is not currently approved by us for export of dogs and cats directly to Australia. Dogs and cats cannot be directly imported from a non-approved country.

Australia must assess and approve any country that wishes to export dogs and cats directly to Australia. We assess the animal health situation and government controls to determine if trade can proceed safely. If a country is not approved, it may be because:

- it hasn't been assessed,
- assessment hasn't been requested, or
- trade may not be able to proceed safely.

If a country wants to be assessed for import of cats and dogs to Australia, it will need to formally contact us.

Official government veterinarian

Official government veterinarians (OGV) are usually employed by the competent authority in the country of export. They generally do not work in a veterinary clinic. Refer to the competent authority to determine the type of veterinarian or OGV you need as terminology may differ.

These veterinarians are authorised to sign (endorse) certificates on behalf of their government. They have access to the official government stamp.

Para-veterinarian

Para-veterinarian (para-vets) are trained to help registered veterinarians. Their training is recognised by the competent health authority in their country.

Rabies Neutralising Antibody Titre Test (RNATT)

Declaration

Dogs and cats produce protective antibodies against rabies after they are vaccinated. The RNATT test measures the amount of these antibodies. If there are enough antibodies, the vaccination is considered successful.

An RNATT declaration is issued by an official government veterinarian of the country of export. They will issue a declaration after you provide:

- a valid rabies vaccination certificate
- a valid RNATT laboratory report.

These documents must show that your cat or dog is vaccinated against rabies.

This is part of the rabies requirements for any cat or dog imported from a Group 3 country.

RNATT received date

The date the blood sample for the Rabies Neutralising Antibody Titre Test (RNATT) is received by the testing laboratory. This is the date the 180-day waiting period is calculated from for animals being exported from a group 3 country. You can find this date on the test results or the RNATT declaration. An RNATT is valid for 12 months or 365 days from the date of blood sampling.

RNATT sampling date

The date of blood sampling for the Rabies Neutralising Antibody Titre Test (RNATT). You can find this date on the test results or the RNATT declaration. An RNATT is valid for 12 months or 365 days from the date of blood sampling.

Submitting laboratory

In some cases, the laboratory that receives your cat or dogs blood test, known as the submitting laboratory, sends the sample on to another laboratory. This is the testing laboratory. The RNATT laboratory report and RNATT declaration need to state the testing laboratory.

Supporting documents

You must submit supporting documents with your import permit application. Keep original documents. Submit copies of each document to us. Check the [step-by-step guide for your country of export](#). The guide will have details of the supporting documents you need.

Testing laboratory

This is the laboratory that performs the RNATT. It must be listed on the RNATT laboratory report and RNATT declaration. This must be a [government approved laboratory](#). The veterinarian preparing your cat or dog for export will be able to determine the appropriate laboratory.

Transshipment

Your animal is unloaded from a plane and is then loaded onto another plane. It stays on the international side of the airport during the transfer.

This can only occur at some airports for animals being exported from a group 2 country. Check the [step-by-step guide for your country of export](#).

Transiting

The plane carrying your cat or dog lands at an airport, but your animal remains on the plane.

Vaccinations

1. Primary vaccination course:

A primary vaccination course is the initial series of vaccine doses that are necessary to develop protective immunity against a specific disease. The primary vaccination course includes multiple vaccinations given within a short time frame. The manufacturers direction will advise on how far apart the vaccinations within the primary course must be given. This must be followed strictly.

2. Ongoing booster vaccinations:

A booster vaccination is an additional dose of a vaccine that is given a year or years after the primary vaccine course. It gives the immune system extra protection from the disease. The manufacturers direction will advise on when the booster vaccination should be given. This must be followed strictly.

Veterinary health certificate

The veterinary health certificate (VHC) is an official document used to confirm that your cat or dog has met Australia's import requirements.

The VHC is developed and agreed between the department and the competent authority of the exporting country. Each country has its own VHC and endorsement process, which may differ between countries. The competent authority controls how VHCs are issued, completed and endorsed.

Before export, a government approved veterinarian usually completes the VHC. The VHC is then endorsed by the competent authority or an official government veterinarian, depending on the country's process.

The department use the VHC to verify that your pet meets Australia's import requirements when it arrives in Australia. It is important that the VHC is completed correctly.

Find detailed advice in the [step-by-step guide for your country of export](#).

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/cats-dogs/frequently-asked-questions/glossary-for-cat-and-dog-import-permit-applications>